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Battle for the Heartland

Every election campaign has a defining moment, an event which changes the course of the contest permanently. In the historic 1977 election, it was the day senior minister Jagjivan Ram left the Congress, signifying the beginning of the end of Indira Gandhi's government. In 2004, it was arguably a stampede over saris being handed out to poor women in Lucknow (where Vajpayee was the BJP candidate), which left twenty-one persons dead, raising the first big question over the Vajpayee government's India Shining campaign. The turning point in the 2014 battle was probably 27 October 2013 when serial blasts ripped through Patna's railway station and Gandhi Maidan where Narendra Modi was holding a massive rally, killing five and injuring more than eighty people.

The rally had been billed as Modi's grand arrival into 'enemy' territory. He had been kept out of Bihar for almost a decade at the chief minister Nitish Kumar's insistence. The BJP had been in an alliance government for eight years with Nitish, who had made it clear that Modi was not welcome in Bihar because of the taint of the Gujarat riots. When Modi was made the BJP's campaign committee chief in June 2013, Nitish had chosen to break the alliance. The war of personalities between Modi and Nitish was not just an ego clash. Priding himself on uncompromising religious neutrality, rugged anti-Congress-ism and plebeian rootedness, Nitish had lost no opportunity after breaking with the BJP to heap veiled scorn on those relying on PR machines, media and advertisements to build their image. Nitish even seemed to be readying to set himself up as a national alternative to Modi, thumbing his nose at a BJP that he felt had betrayed his trust. The BJP was yearning for revenge.